

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 719

By Bulso

A RESOLUTION to honor the memory of Lewis "Lew" H. Conner, Jr., of Nashville.

WHEREAS, the members of this General Assembly were greatly saddened to learn of the passing of Lewis "Lew" H. Conner, Jr., of Nashville; and

WHEREAS, a highly respected attorney, judge, and philanthropist, Lew Conner was an exemplary public servant and consummate professional who worked assiduously to improve the quality of life for his fellow citizens in numerous capacities; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Conner was a native of Chattanooga and a proud graduate of Vanderbilt University, where he earned his Bachelor of Arts degree in 1960 and his Juris Doctor degree in 1963; during his collegiate career, he served as president of Alpha Tau Omega and competed on the Men's Varsity Golf Team from 1957 to 1960; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Conner's commitment to Vanderbilt deepened over the years, and in 2017, he was inducted into the Vanderbilt Sports Hall of Fame, an honor that reflected not only his role as an athlete but also his contributions as an innovator and visionary benefactor; and

WHEREAS, Lew Conner was instrumental in elevating Vanderbilt Golf to national prominence, and his legacy is physically etched on campus through the Conner Family Hitting Bays and the Conner Short Game Practice Facility at the Vanderbilt Legends Club, a state-of-the-art practice facility that ensures generations of Commodores have the tools to excel; and

WHEREAS, often referred to as a "statesman of the game," Mr. Conner was the founder and first amateur president of the Tennessee Golf Foundation, in which he served as the primary architect of the Golf House Tennessee concept, an endeavor that ultimately unified the Tennessee Golf Association and the Tennessee Section of the PGA; additionally, he served the

organization as chairman and was a longtime director and president of the Tennessee Golf Association; and

WHEREAS, an elite competitor, Lew Conner won thirty-five amateur tournaments and secured both the 1973 Tennessee Amateur Player of the Year title and the inaugural Tennessee Golfers' Person of the Year award in 2002; in 1996, he competed in both the USGA Senior Amateur and Senior Open Championships, and in 2010, he was inducted into the Tennessee Golf Hall of Fame; and

WHEREAS, following his service as a Captain in the Judge Advocate General's Corps with the 101st Airborne Division (1963-1966), Mr. Conner entered private practice and went on to cofound Dearborn & Ewing with partners who remained lifelong friends; as his private practice career unfolded, his work in complex litigation led him to pioneer Alternative Dispute Resolution in Tennessee; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Conner was widely regarded as one of the "fathers of mediation," and his legal career was marked by a steadfast commitment to integrity and service and an extraordinary record of successful resolutions; and

WHEREAS, Lew Conner was a recipient of the John C. Tune Public Service Award, the highest distinction from the Nashville Bar Association, and the Best of the Bar Lifetime Achievement Award; and

WHEREAS, a leader in his profession, Lew Conner served on the Tennessee Court of Appeals with distinction from 1980 to 1984, and he later served as special chief justice of the Tennessee Supreme Court; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Conner was a trusted advisor and strategist, having served as a finance co-chair and counsel to many of Tennessee's most prominent leaders, including Lamar Alexander, Fred Thompson, Bill Frist, Don Sundquist, Bill Haslam, and Bill Hagerty, and mentored countless others in public service; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Conner held leadership roles within the Boys & Girls Clubs, the Nashville Sports Council, the Music City Bowl, and the National Commodore Club, and he was a devoted member of Westminster Presbyterian Church; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Conner was also deeply devoted to his family, and he always endeavored to remain true to family values of the highest order; and

WHEREAS, left to cherish his memory are his college sweetheart and beloved wife of sixty-five years, Ashley Whitsitt Conner; his children, Holland (Holly) Conner Boyer and Lewis Forrest Conner; his children's spouses, David Boyer and Stephanie Barger Conner; and his grandchildren, Forrest Walker Conner, Elizabeth Lewis Conner, Virginia Ashley Conner, Luke Coleman Boyer, and Martha Ashley Boyer; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Conner was preceded in death by his parents, Lewis H. Conner and Cleo Johnson Conner, and his grandson, John Carlisle Conner; and

WHEREAS, Lew Conner leaves behind an indelible legacy of integrity and probity in public life, compassion and loyalty in private life, and diligence and dedication in all his chosen endeavors; and

WHEREAS, it is fitting that the members of this General Assembly should pause to remember the bountiful life of this exceptional public servant and human being; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we honor the memory of Lewis "Lew" H. Conner, Jr., reflecting fondly upon his impeccable character, his extraordinary contributions to the people of Tennessee, and his stalwart commitment to living the examined life with courage and conviction.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that we express our sympathy and offer our condolences to the family of Mr. Conner.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.